

SILENT WITNESS

By Alex Michaelides

Elara Vance considered herself a creature of logic and fact. Her apartment in the bustling heart of the city was a testament to her pragmatic nature: sleek, minimalist, and devoid of the sentimental clutter that often choked the lives of others. As an aspiring historian, she dealt in verifiable truths, not the nebulous narratives of folklore or superstition. So, when the call came about her Great-Aunt Mildred's passing, followed by the bewildering news that Elara was the sole inheritor of the old woman's estate, her primary emotion was not grief, but a detached curiosity.

Mildred, a distant relative whom Elara had met only once as a child, had been an enigma, a name whispered with a mixture of pity and dismissive disdain within the family. "Mad Mildred," they'd called her, after she'd retreated to her remote, decaying ancestral home, severing ties with the world. Now, that home, and everything within it, was Elara's.

The house sat nestled at the end of a long, overgrown gravel drive, shrouded by ancient, skeletal trees that seemed to claw at the perpetually overcast sky. It was a relic, a testament to neglect. Dust motes danced in the sparse shafts of sunlight that pierced the grimy windows, illuminating forgotten furniture draped in white sheets like slumbering ghosts. The air was thick with the scent of mildew, forgotten spices, and something else – a faint, metallic tang that Elara couldn't quite place.

After navigating the labyrinthine downstairs, Elara ascended the creaking stairs to the attic. It was here, amidst a chaotic jumble of moth-eaten textiles, rusted tools, and stacks of yellowed newspapers, that she found it. Standing upright against a wall, shrouded in a heavy, velvet cloth, was a full-length mirror. It was surprisingly tall, almost reaching the ceiling, its

frame an elaborate, dark mahogany, intricately carved with swirling vines and grimacing faces that seemed to emerge from the wood itself. Even veiled, it exuded a strange, undeniable presence.

Curiosity piqued, Elara pulled away the cloth. The mirror's surface, despite decades of dust, seemed to gleam with an unsettling depth. Her own reflection, usually so familiar, looked a touch too pale, her eyes a fraction too wide in its aged glass. A shiver, not entirely due to the attic's chill, traced its way down her spine. The mirror felt unusually cold to the touch, a deep, pervasive cold that seemed to sink into her bones. It was a beautiful, albeit somewhat ominous, piece. Its historical value alone made it worth keeping. She decided it would look magnificent in the main living area, a stark contrast to the house's decay. With a grunt of effort, she managed to manoeuvre the heavy object downstairs, placing it carefully against a prominent wall in what would become her temporary study.

The first few days were a blur of unpacking and attempting to bring some semblance of order to the chaotic house. Elara mostly ignored the mirror, preoccupied with the more pressing matters of clearing cobwebs and airing out musty rooms. But slowly, subtly, its presence began to assert itself.

It started with fleeting glances. Walking past, she'd catch a glimpse of her reflection, but something would be off. Her eyes might seem to hold a fleeting expression of terror that vanished the instant she focused. Or the familiar pattern of the wallpaper behind her would momentarily warp, ripple, or even darken, only to settle back into normalcy. She'd blink, rub her eyes, and dismiss it as fatigue from the long days, or the distorting effects of old glass. After all, it was an antique.

Then came the temperature drops. The air around the mirror, even in the warmth of the afternoon sun filtering through the windows, felt distinctively colder. It was a pervasive, unnatural chill that seemed to radiate from the glass itself. Elara, ever the rationalist, blamed poor insulation, drafty windows – anything but the mirror. Yet, she found herself unconsciously avoiding prolonged proximity to it, a growing, unacknowledged unease taking root.

One evening, engrossed in sorting through a box of Mildred's old books, Elara glanced up, her gaze inadvertently falling upon the mirror. For a split second, something *else* was there. Not her reflection. A woman's face, pale and contorted, her mouth open in a silent, agonizing scream. Her eyes, wide and filled with an ancient despair, met Elara's across the polished surface. Then, as quickly as it appeared, it was gone, replaced by her own startled, bewildered reflection.

Elara gasped, dropping the book. Her heart hammered against her ribs. She stared, wide-eyed, at the mirror. Nothing. Just the familiar room, her own reflection, slightly distorted by the old glass. Had she imagined it? Was the isolation of the house, the sheer amount of dust she'd inhaled, finally getting to her? She shook her head, trying to clear the image from her mind, but the lingering sense of dread was palpable.

It was during her subsequent, more meticulous exploration of Mildred's personal effects that Elara found them: a collection of leather-bound journals, tucked away in a locked desk drawer, each filled with Mildred's increasingly frantic handwriting. They were not, as the family had implied, the incoherent ramblings of a madwoman. They were the desperate entries of a soul under immense torment, struggling to articulate an unbearable truth.

The early entries were mundane, snippets of daily life. But as Elara delved deeper, the tone shifted. Mildred wrote of "the Eye," "the Burden," "the whispers in the glass," and "the truth that never fades." She spoke of "watching" and "being watched," of "the weight of every tear, every lie, every blow." Her language was cryptic, yet strangely compelling. Elara, the aspiring historian, felt a familiar pull – the thrill of uncovering a hidden narrative.

As Elara continued to read Mildred's increasingly agitated journals, the mirror's manifestations intensified. The fleeting glimpses became longer, more vivid. She no longer questioned her sanity; the horrors it presented were too real, too visceral to be mere figments of her imagination.

One afternoon, a sharp, metallic clang from the kitchen startled her. She hurried in, finding a dropped pot. As she bent to pick it up, her reflection in the mirror at the end of the hallway seemed to shimmer. She straightened slowly, her eyes fixed on the glass.

The room in the reflection wasn't hers. It was an older version, cluttered with heavy, dark furniture. A man, his face a mask of grief, knelt by a bedside, his shoulders shaking with silent sobs. A woman lay on the bed, still, her face obscured by shadows. The reflection was colourless, like an old photograph, yet the despair radiating from it was overwhelming, palpable. Elara felt a wave of crushing sorrow, an emotion so profound it stole her breath. Then, the image flickered, distorted, and her own study, mundane and dusty, returned.

Another time, she was polishing the frame, running her fingers over the intricately carved wood. Suddenly, the glass rippled like disturbed water. Dark, amorphous shapes writhed behind her reflection, coalescing into what looked like hands reaching out, their fingers long and skeletal. A

guttural, silent snarl seemed to echo in the room, not heard, but *felt*. Elara recoiled, stumbling backwards, her heart a frantic drum against her ribs. The mirror settled, its surface calm, innocent. But she knew. This was no ordinary haunting.

Mildred's later journal entries, found hidden beneath loose floorboards in her bedroom, offered the terrifying explanation. "It is not haunted *by* them," Mildred had scrawled, her hand trembling across the yellowed page. "It *is* the haunting. The Eye. It absorbs. Every fear, every despair, every act of cruelty – it takes it in. It drinks it. And it never lets go. The glass is a sponge for suffering. It shows not ghosts, but the *memory* of their agony. The imprint. The truth that never fades."

Mildred wrote of her desperate attempts to destroy it. She'd tried axes, hammers, fire – but the glass remained flawless, impenetrable. She'd attempted to seal it away, but the oppressive cold, the psychic pressure, had permeated walls, had crept under locked doors. "It speaks without sound," Mildred had penned in a final, barely legible entry. "It screams silently. And I… I have become its latest ear. Its keeper. Its witness." Mildred's descent into what the family called madness wasn't madness at all; it was the unbearable burden of witnessing centuries of absorbed pain.

Elara stared at the mirror. Mildred's words resonated with a terrifying clarity. It wasn't about a vengeful spirit or a demonic entity. It was far worse. The mirror was a silent archive of horror, a vessel for the accumulated anguish of generations. Every twisted reflection, every silent scream, every fleeting glimpse of despair wasn't a visitation from the past, but the mirror *showing* what it held, what it had absorbed. It

was a black hole for human suffering, and Elara, by inheriting it, had now become connected to it.

The psychological toll began to mount. Elara found herself plagued by nightmares filled with silent cries and shadowy figures. A pervasive cold settled in her bones, a cold that had nothing to do with the house's drafts. She felt a constant, inexplicable despair, a heavy blanket of sadness that was not her own. The mirror wasn't actively malicious, but its very existence was a form of psychological torture. It was a burden, a heavy, invisible weight.

She tried everything to get rid of it. Listing it online was a joke – who would buy something that radiated such oppressive dread? She attempted to smash it again, wielding a heavy sledgehammer she found in the shed, but the mirror's surface was impossibly resilient, deflecting every blow without a scratch. It felt as though some unseen force was gently but firmly pushing the hammer away, making her arms ache with futility. She tried to move it, to drag it out of the house, but its weight was immense, defying all her strength, as if rooted to the floor. Even when she covered it completely with thick, dark blankets, the feeling of being watched persisted, the air around it remained cold, and the subtle distortions of reality seemed to ripple out, affecting other surfaces, other reflections in the house.

One evening, Elara stood before the mirror, the blankets having long been discarded. Her reflection stared back, haggard and pale, dark circles under her eyes. As she watched, a subtle shift occurred. The lines of her face seemed to deepen, her eyes to hollow slightly, taking on a familiar, ancient weariness. It was Mildred's face, not fully formed, but an echo, a faint, translucent overlay beneath her own.

A profound, chilling understanding settled over Elara. She couldn't destroy it. She couldn't escape it. The mirror was not just an object in her house; it was now an indelible part of her inheritance, a dark, silent lineage she had unwittingly accepted. It would continue to observe, to absorb, to hold onto every unspeakable act, every hidden grief, every silent scream. And she, Elara Vance, the pragmatist, the historian of facts, was now bound to it. She was its latest keeper. Its unwilling, eternal, silent witness.

As the last vestiges of twilight faded from the sky, her reflection in the ancient glass seemed to twist, a fleeting, silent terror flickering beneath the surface of her eyes, a testament to the horror that had found its new home. The mirror simply watched, silent, eternal, its burden now inextricably linked with hers.